

sat in the balcony with his favourite single malt and let his mind drift over his own career. As he looked out towards the sea of skyscrapers—most of them half-completed buildings abandoned by real estate developers—that is Greater Noida, Mr Talwar's mind retraced the steps of his distinguished corporate career.

He had done well academically. After completing his undergraduate degree in engineering from the highly rated Regional Engineering College in Telangana's Warangal (formerly Andhra Pradesh), he had gone on to finish his studies at a reputed business school—Management Development Institute (MDI) in Gurgaon. His MBA from MDI, coupled with a solid academic record, had helped Yogesh Talwar get a good job with a leading multinational company with an attractive salary of Rs 2 lakh per annum. He had stars in his eyes and the world was his to conquer. That was 1990, but it seemed like yesterday.

The years had flown by since then, but even in the tumult of post-1991 India, Mr Talwar had broadly done the right things. To begin with, he had married a smart girl. Kusum was a teacher at a private school in Noida. Kusum and Yogesh's children, Akanksha and Ronit, were bright, hard-working and well-behaved. Akanksha was pursuing a postgraduate degree in biotechnology in Bangalore and Ronit was awaiting his engineering entrance exam results. Mr Talwar had a settled life, and yet he felt deeply unsettled.

Over the years, especially in the last four to five years, he had started feeling like an underachiever despite working hard over his twenty-five-year corporate career. When he had started working, he told himself that he would retire at the age of forty. That forty had become forty-five and now here he was at fifty years of age. And yet, despite all the hard work, Mr Talwar felt almost as financially insecure as he was when he graduated from business school.

He had started working in 1990, just as India was about to open its doors to liberalization. It was a good time to work with a private firm. His career had progressed better compared to some of his friends who had joined public sector companies. The yearly increments were great too. For the first few years, the young Yogesh never needed to save. He spent his income on a